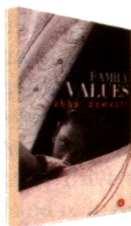


Relative Allegory

A chronicle of the elusive qualities of love and care that run through most families

By Brinda Bose



FAMILY VALUES
by ABHA DAWESAR
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Family Values is read as an urban allegory, then clearly the title is an ironic one. In Abha Dawesar's latest novel, the city is Delhi, but it remains unnamed and unidentified by street or structure. Its chief protagonist is the young son of feverishly-dedicated doctor parents, growing up somewhat off-beat in their shabby, single-roomed, partitioned-by-curtains home. The family that Dawesar chronicles consists of cousins and uncles and aunts known by such evocative nicknames as Mrs Cowdung, Six Fingers, Psoriasis, Sugar Mills, Flunkie Junkie. The protagonist is "the boy", and at the novel's most minimalist, his grandfather is Grandfather and a cousin is Cousin. The novel's prose matches its content—as well as intent—step for step with sparseness; and if there is a precarious centre at all (that does not hold, fittingly enough), it is the unlikely one of scatology.

Dawesar is building up a reputation for periodically producing novels that are distinctive, even intriguing. Though *Family Values* returns us to the city of her first novel *Babyji* about Delhi schoolgirl Anamika, "the boy" and his world in this latest work of fiction could not be farther removed from the girl's, excreta-fixation not the only reason for its divergence. The boy is frail and bony, with a tummy that is perpetually on the verge of giving way. Correspondingly, perhaps, but unfairly, the toilet in his bleak abode is also on the edge of collapse; Dawesar, in terse but unrelentingly honest prose, describes the family's daily tribulations within it in extravagant detail. And thereby hangs a tale, one assumes.

The novel interrogates and critiques "family values" as we might understand it in right-wing-tainted contexts,

and yet affirms and endorses its implications in some larger, dispersed sense, if we can remain cognisant of the elusive qualities of grace and love and caring that run like a tenuous thread through most families, if often near-invisibly. What Dawesar offers in a distinctively spare register—which she describes as "black and white"—is a skeletal mapping of the intricacies of familial relationships as they play themselves out against the stark backdrop of a penurious urban existence, with a nuclear unit, comprising the boy and his doctor parents, at its pivot.

In true allegorical mode, *Family Values* operates at multiple levels of specificity and universality: the boy is both the stomach-churned offspring of two doctors perpetually distracted by diseases dancing in macabre fashion, and Everyboy; his parents are both identifiably his in their quirky, equal love for their child and patients, and Everyparent; his extended family may be made up of distinctive characters but there are Flunkie Junkies in all our families as we know, and the boy's is, ultimately, Everyfamily, caught in the ebb and flow of genealogical fortunes. And this is not all: the family is a microcosmic representation of the larger world outside, the classic

private/public mirror held up to expose the macrocosm, to illustrate the essential connectedness of human behaviour through all its diverse fancies and foibles.

Dawesar's experiment in marrying form to content—stark, capricious, raw prose for a grim expose of life's little and big ironies, relieved only occasionally by flashes of humour and tenderness—is ambitious, but only partially successful. Ironically, it is perhaps the relentlessness of its linguistic enterprise that proves the impediment to a true marriage. As always, Dawesar leaves a mark, of course, but with a few ragged, jagged edges. ■



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